during the 1988 uprising,[68] initially led by a serving general, a former general (Tin Oo) and Aung San Suu Kyi. This coalition was not accidental. The NLD saw itself as reaching back to the anti-colonial tradition of being both a mass party and an elite organisation that also combined civilian and military elements. The problem was that in its initial incarnation it was indeed an elite party,[69] drawing its leadership initially from those in the governing elite who had fallen foul of Ne Win. While the party appealed to the protesting students, it had no direct connection with the bulk of the Burmese population. This connection was provided by the monks who were at the forefront of the protests. By allying with the monks, the NLD gained the support of a group who were widely respected by most Burmese and able to give the NLD the electoral base it needed.

The NLD boycotted the 2010 elections (partly because Aung San Suu Kyi was banned from standing) but did take part in the limited set of elections in 2012, winning forty-three out of forty-five contests.[70] It has since won a landslide victory in the 2015 elections, but problems remain for it. One is that Aung San Suu Kyi is still debarred from becoming president[71] (though she was allowed to run for parliament this time). This concern connects with the current factional dispute within the USDP, in which some elements may be prepared to do a deal with the NLD to retain some power after its electoral defeat[72] and may even be prepared to consider a form of national unity government between the USDP and the NLD. The immediate post-election period suggests that this outcome remains possible.

A second problem for the NLD is that while it seeks to be multi-ethnic, its electoral base remains the Burman ethnic communities (and it has expelled most of its Muslim members);[73] this leaves it very reliant on the Buddhist monks to influence the Burman electorate. Unfortunately, since 1988 the monks have become intensely anti-Islamic and they demand that the NLD support their positions; if it does not then it forfeits their support.

Regional political parties

The 1988 events also saw the emergence of a range of single-ethnicity parties that contested districts in their own state. The most important, in terms of this book, was the party formed to represent the Buddhist Rakhine